This book has three main messages. The first is that quantum mechanics should be understandable—even if we're not there yet—and achieving such understanding should be a high-priority goal of modern science. Quantum mechanics is unique among physical theories in drawing an apparent distinction between *what we see* and *what really is*. That poses a special challenge to the minds of scientists (and everyone else), who are used to thinking about what we see as unproblematically "real," and working to explain things accordingly. But this challenge isn't insuperable, and if we free our minds from certain old-fashioned and intuitive ways of thinking, we find that quantum mechanics isn't hopelessly mystical or inexplicable. It's just physics.

The second message is that we have made real progress toward understanding. I will focus on the approach I feel is clearly the most promising route, the Everett or Many-Worlds formulation of quantum mechanics. Many-Worlds has been enthusiastically embraced by many physicists, but it has a sketchy reputation among people who are put off by a proliferation of other realities containing copies of themselves. If you are one of those people, I want to at least convince you that Many-Worlds is the *purest* way of making sense of quantum mechanics—it's where we end up if we just follow the path of least resistance in taking quantum phenomena seriously. In particular, the multiple worlds are predictions of the formalism that is already in place, not something added in by hand. But Many-Worlds isn't the only respectable approach, and we will mention some of its main competitors. (I will endeavor to be fair, if not necessarily balanced.) The important thing is that the various approaches are all well-constructed scientific theories, with potentially different experimental ramifications, not just woolly-headed "interpretations" to be debated over cognac and cigars after we're finished doing real work.

The third message is that all this matters, and not just for the integrity of science. The success to date of the existing adequate-but-not-perfectly-coherent framework of quantum mechanics shouldn't blind us to the fact that there are circumstances under which such an approach simply isn't up to the task. In particular, when we turn to understanding the nature of spacetime itself, and the origin and ultimate fate of the entire universe, the foundations of quantum mechanics are absolutely crucial. I'll introduce